

David Viewing's Gauge One starter engine

The Greenly 0-4-0

Builder's Guide



David Viewing with Adrian Johnstone – update E issued 4th June 2026



Published by the Gauge One 3D Circle - a specialist group within **G1MRA**

The Gauge 1 Model Railway Association

<https://www.g1mra.com>

Preface

This document is for those interested in building a Greenly Starter Engine using one of the kits available from G1MRA. You can order a kit from <http://www.g1mra.com/> under the **Sales/Models** tab.

The kit comes in three variants: A: Ready to Run (RTR), B: pluggable and C: solderable.

Type A (Ready to Run) models are complete and usable out of the box but they are **undecorated**. The locomotive as delivered looks like the white engine pictured on the front cover. Type B (pluggable) models need assembly skills, but the electronics has been wired up for you and just needs to be plugged together. Type C (solderable) models are not wired up: you need electronics construction experience to tackle one of these.

If you are building a kit, simply work through all sections of this guide in sequence. If you get stuck, you'll find advice and contact emails on the G1MRA web site.

The main body of the text (sections 1-12) will take you through the construction of a Type B kit.

Appendix A covers the wiring and soldering needed to connect together the electronic components in a type C kit; effectively explaining how to make a type B kit from a type C kit. Appendix B contains hints and exercises to help the novice learn electronic soldering skills.

All of the design and development of these kits, along with the work needed to identify a cost-effective supply chain is the work of David Viewing.

Adrian Johnstone supplied a little encouragement and wrote most of this guide whilst constructing both a pilot and a production variant.

Many others have helped and offered suggestions, especially those attending the 3D Circle Zoom group and the builders of the ten pilot engines. Thank you to everybody involved.

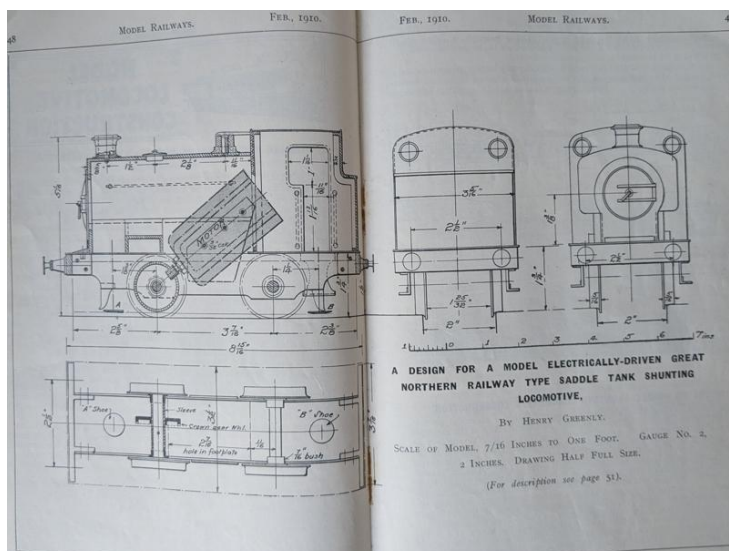
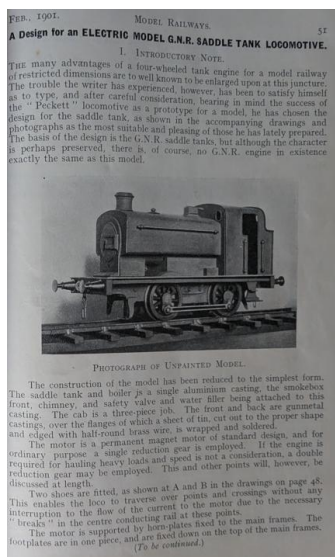
Adrian and David, June 2026

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1: Background to the project

In the February 1910 issue of his magazine *Model Railways and Locomotives* Henry Greenly introduced a construction series for a simple 0-4-0 locomotive. He wrote '*The basis of the design is the G.N.R saddle tanks, but although the character is perhaps preserved, there is, of course, no GNR engine in existence exactly the same as this model*'. Henry is presumably referring to the GNR class J13-J17 0-6-0 saddle tank engines designed by Stirling.



Greenly's article finishes with the fatal words *To be continued* but as far as we know, there were no further instalments. The model as originally described is Gauge 2 (two inches between the rails) not Gauge 1. It seems that some models were sold commercially of which at least one survives, featuring an aluminium one-piece casting for the saddle tank. David Viewing owns the surviving example, and designed a radio control 3D printed chassis to go beneath it. He then developed bodywork in three sizes to go with it.



Here we see the whole family. From left to right: (i) the original Henry Greenly Gauge 2 body atop a modern chassis; (ii) in white, a Gauge 3 resin print; (iii) David's Gauge 2 prototype printed in black nylon with a coloured vinyl wrap; and (iv) on the right David's prototype Gauge 1 engine, printed in black nylon and sprayed with car-paint rattle cans.

The Gauge One Model Railway Association (G1MRA) has a long tradition of promoting 'starter' locomotives as an introduction to live steam, and recognised that a low-cost electric loco would also be an attractive way into large scale modelling. David found that Henry's simple design could be economically reproduced using

commercial 3D printing technologies, and also researched low-cost radio control and even ultrasonic ‘smoke’ generators.

The prototypes were well-received by the G1MRA committee who then financially underwrote the production of ten pilot kits, with costs recovered from those builders who bought kits. At the 2025 AGM in Darlington, G1MRA awarded the 2025 President’s Cup to David Viewing for this initiative, who then demonstrated the prototypes running at speed with a full load on the Midland Group’s Carding Road track: you can watch a video of that run at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jOOP2zo-2o0>

Feedback from the ten pilot builders led to an improved V7.1 design in which the electronics were mounted in a separate backhead assembly to avoid water spillage from the smoke generator. At the same time, David added some detailing to the cab, and a flickering LED to simulate an open firebox.

This production version was formally launched with an article in the March 2026 edition of G1MRA’s *Newsletter and Journal*. An initial run of twenty kits sold out immediately, with many collected at the Spring 2026 G1MRA meeting at Statfold Barn. Towards the end of the day, the Anglia Roads outer electric track was taken over by a procession of four trains, each hauled by a Greenly starter engine.

The lead train comprised eleven RCH wagons, a van and a brake van: this was easily handled by the engine.



Also on track was Elizabeth Scott’s Cadbury No. 15 loco hauling heavily weighted Northern Finescale vans along with Steve Andrews’ NCB loco and brake van, and Roger Hopkin’s Archie.



2: Check that you have everything

Here are the main elements of the kit as supplied.



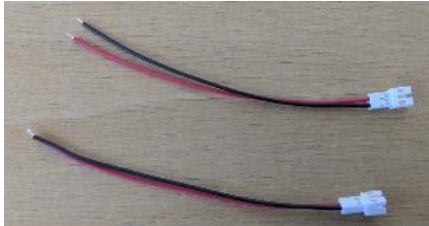
Please check that you have all of the following items. Note that the electrics shown are for a type C kit; for a type B kit they will already have been wired together and only need to be plugged together and tested which we will do in Section 6.

Electronics

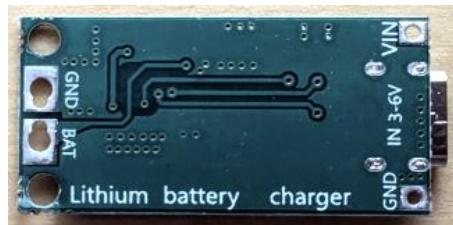
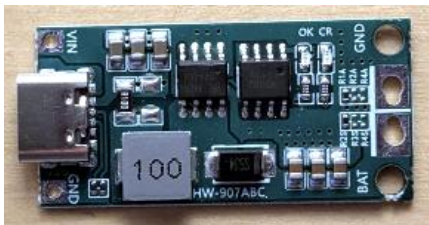
1. Two protected LIPO pouch cells. **Treat LIPO batteries with great care! Do not puncture the pouches or short circuit the connections!**



2. Two LIPO battery connectors and wires. **Do not connect batteries to leads before they are soldered up as the loose leads may touch and short circuit the battery. Keep them separate for now.**



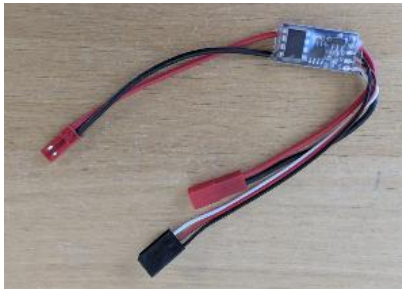
3. Battery charger board fitted with a USB-C connector.



4. A single pole, double throw (SPDT) toggle switch that connects the batteries to *either* the charger board or the electronic speed controller. When not in use, switch off by connecting to the charger board.



5. Electronic speed controller. The three-way Futaba connector plugs into the radio control receiver. The (socket) two-way connector at the same end as the three-way connector goes via the switch to the batteries; the other (plug) two-way connector goes to the motor.



6. Motor RS-385PH-2270 or RS385PV-2270.



7. Radio control receiver with attached short aerial lead, and a telemetry lead which will allow battery levels to be sent back to the hand-held transmitter. Keep these in the box for now.



8. Hand-held radio control transmitter, boxed with manual, charging lead and wrist cord.



9. Flickering firebox LED with Futaba connector



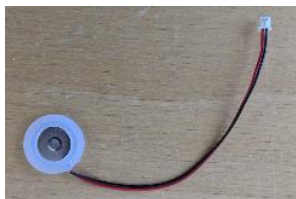
10. Hall effect sensor to control 'smoke' puffs



11. JST three-wire connectors for Hall effect sensor



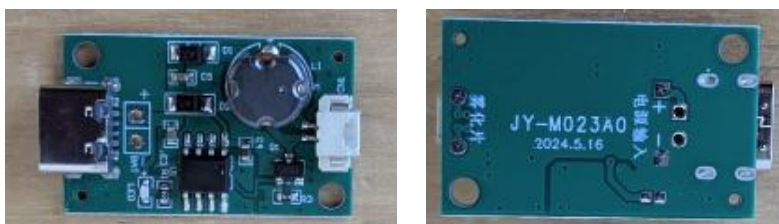
12. Ultrasonic 'smoke' nebuliser disc



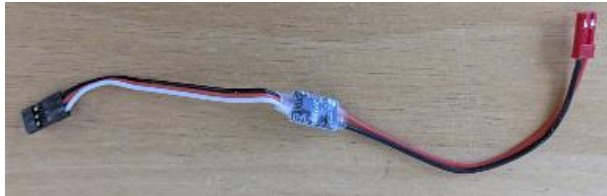
13. Nebuliser wick



14. Ultrasonic control board – note this USB-C connector is not used



15. Ultrasonic interrupter switch



16. JST two-wire connector leads



Gearbox

17. Printed nylon sprue with gearbox components

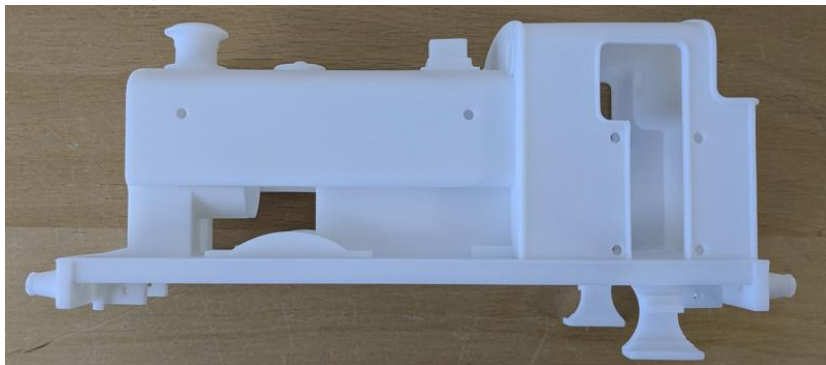


18. Two 5mm diameter axles, two 3mm diameter axles and one RZ-3 crown wheel bearing

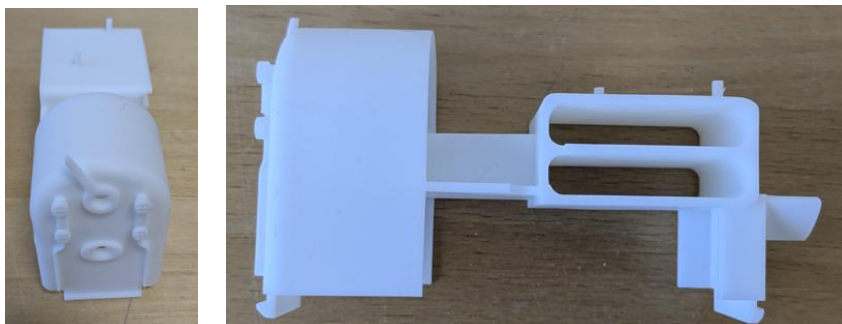


Body and chassis

19. Printed body in white resin



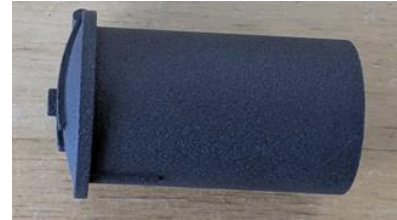
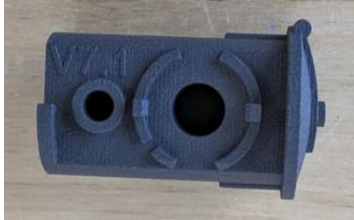
20. Printed backhead and electronics carrier in white resin



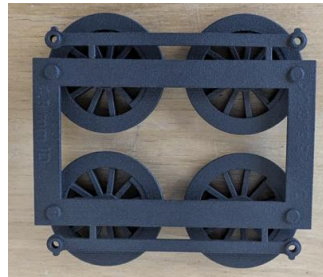
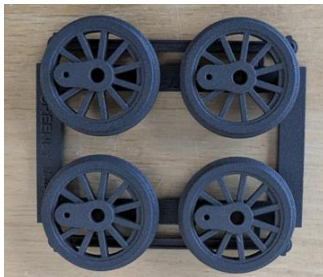
21. Printed black nylon chassis



22. Printed black nylon smoke generator and firebox door



23. Printed nylon sprue with wheels and coupling rods



24. Printed nylon sprue with axle boxes and handrail knobs



25. Printed nylon sprue with further handrail knobs



26. Printed nylon sprue with buffers and coupling hooks



27. Four 2.5mm inside diameter buffer springs



28. One length (or four 10mm long cut pieces) of 2mm outside diameter spring for suspension



29. Two pieces of clock chain for three-link couplings



30. Four M2.5 8mm round head hex socket crankpins (coupling rod screws) with hex key



31. Four M2.5 buffer retaining nuts



32. Two M2.6 motor mounting screws



33. Four M3 slot head body fixing screws



34. Two 2mm diameter by 3mm Neodymium magnets



35. (Optional – not supplied) M2.5 by 6mm charging board fixing screw



36. (Optional – not supplied) Two 2.5mm diameter by 4mm grub screws for final drive gear



37. (Optional – not supplied) Steel or brass 1-2mm rod for hand rails



38. (Optional – not supplied) 180g of self-adhesive tyre balance weights for ballast

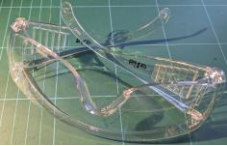


3: Collect tools

1. A cutting mat to protect your work surface



2. Safety glasses, particularly when cutting parts from sprues as they can fly off at speed



3. A 3mm slotted head screwdriver and a size 00 Philips driver



4. A robust craft knife, preferably with a retractable blade



5. A small electric drill or rotary tool - I prefer the trigger operated style of electric drill as it gives me more control when I am opening out holes in plastic.



6. Sharp 2mm, 3mm and 5mm drill bits



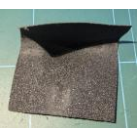
7. Substantial side cutters for removing parts from sprues. I use a Xuron 2175 track cutter



8. A vice, to press wheels on with



9. Some emery paper or a small file to take the edge off of the pre-cut axles

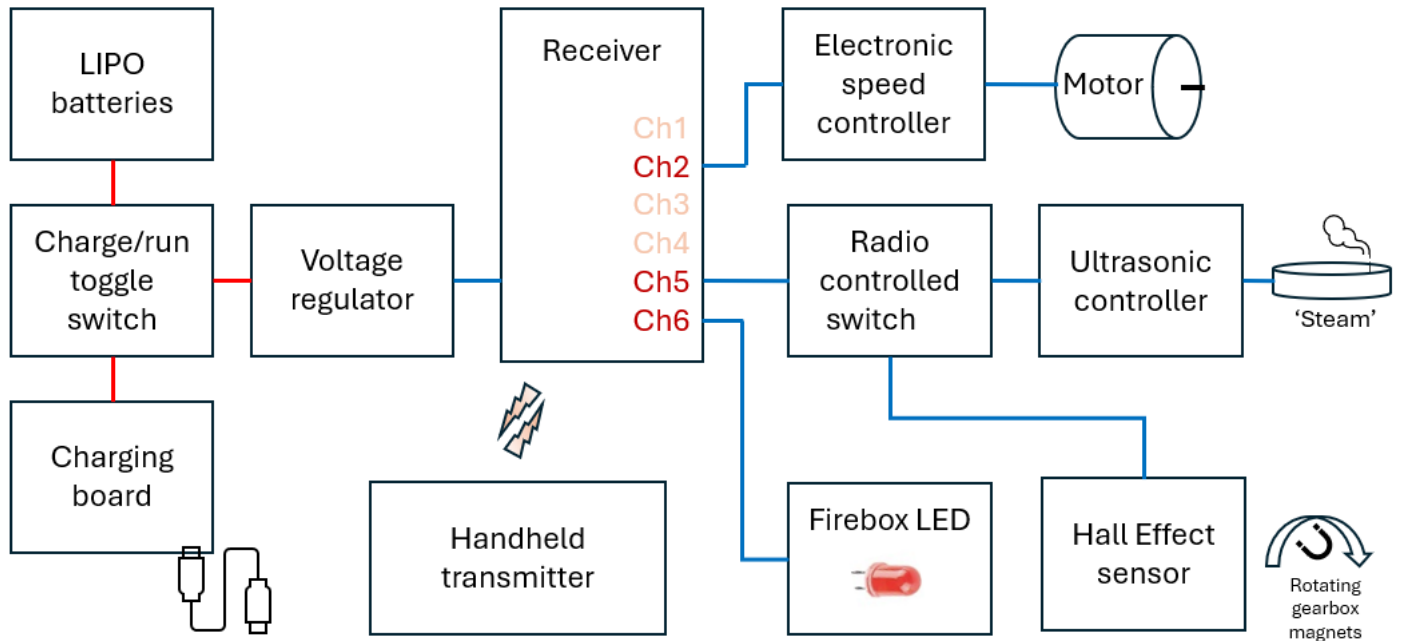


10. A digital caliper may be useful to ensure that the right size screws are being used



4: Understand the electronic blocks

This is a block diagram showing the electronic components and their interconnections.



Power

Power is supplied by two protected LIPO batteries wired in series to produce a nominal 7.4V supply. A charging board allows a USB-C power supply to be connected to the batteries, and a toggle switch selects between charging and run modes. When not in use, the switch is left in the 'charge' position to avoid battery drain. A full charge should allow several hours of loco operation depending on load. The unregulated 7.4V supply is regulated down to 5V. (In detail, the voltage regulator is physically on the Electronic Speed Controller board but we have shown them separately here as they are independent functions.)

Radio control

The radio control system is based around the commercial HOT-RC DS600 radio control system which provides a cost-effective hand-held transmitter and receiver. The transmitter may be used with multiple receivers, but only one may be switched on at a time.

Importantly, the controller provides 'cruise control' - pressing the button underneath causes the system to maintain that speed without needing joystick inputs: just what we need for continuous running.

The transmitter has its own USB-C charging port; a full charge should give around 15 hours of transmitter operation.

The system provides six independent channels, three of which are in use in this loco. The joystick on the handheld controller sends a proportional signal to channel 1 for left/right motion and channel 2 for up/down motion. We only want to control motor speed, and use channel 2 so that up and down movement of the stick controls the engine's speed.

Channels 3-6 are on/off only, controlled by the four buttons arranged in a diamond on the controller. Channel 5 (the leftmost button) switches the smoke generator on and off. The other buttons are not presently used. Channel 6 on the receiver is used simply to supply power to the flickering firebox LED.

The system also has a single 'telemetry' back channel, which allows the transmitter to display the received signal strength and battery voltage at the receiver. If the receiver voltage approaches 7V, then it is time to put the loco on charge.

Motor control

The motor speed and direction are controlled by an Electronic Speed Controller (ESC), which is a standard piece of radio control equipment that plugs into the receiver and converts proportional inputs at the transmitter into pulses of electricity that drive the motor. The ESC has a three-wire connector called a Futaba connector that plugs directly into channel 2 of the receiver. It has a two-wire connection to the battery power, and a two-wire connection to the motor.

'Smoke' generator

The 'smoke' is really just a fine mist of water droplets, created by shaking a metal disk up and down at 108kHz. A water tank under the disk and a wick are used to provide a supply of water to the mist generator. Left to itself, the ultrasonic controller board will excite the disk continuously, but we use a radio-controlled electronic switch connected to channel 5 to modulate the power supply to the ultrasonic board, and thus the output of 'steam'.

The electronic switch only powers the ultrasonics if (i) channel 5 is switched on *and* (ii) the Hall effect sensor detects a nearby magnet. The locomotive gearbox contains a wheel with two embedded magnets that rotate with the main drive axle, giving two pulses per revolution which then switch on the smoke generator for two quarters of each revolution, creating puffs of 'smoke'.

Firebox LED

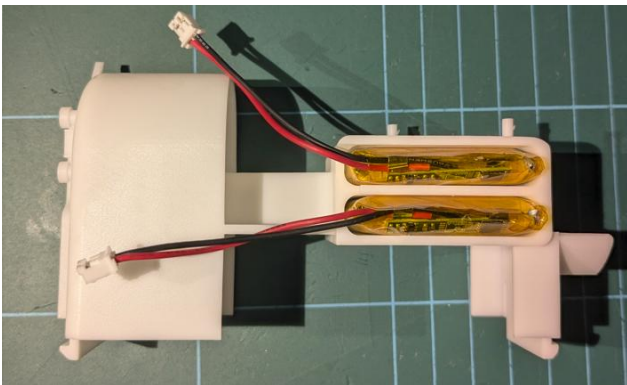
Red/orange light emitting diodes (LEDs) are available which have a built-in flicker. Simply by connecting one to the channel 6 power rail we create a firebox glow effect in the cab.

5: Initial physical battery check

LiPo batteries are remarkable devices but must be treated with respect. They must not be over-charged or over-discharged. Fortunately, the supplied batteries come with a small built-in circuit board which protects the cell against over- and under-voltage conditions. They come already partially charged so if your batteries are not showing any charge at all then they are duds and should be replaced.

Do not at this stage connect the flying leads for the batteries to avoid an accidental short circuit.

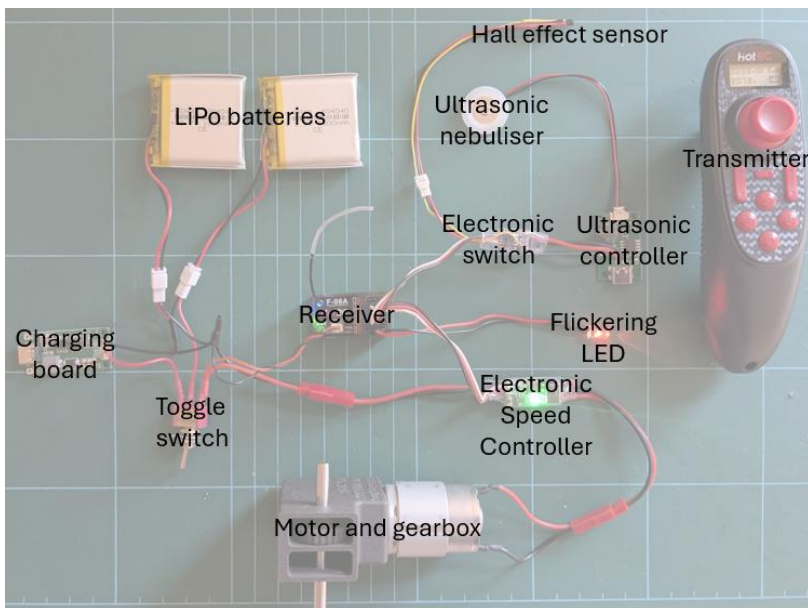
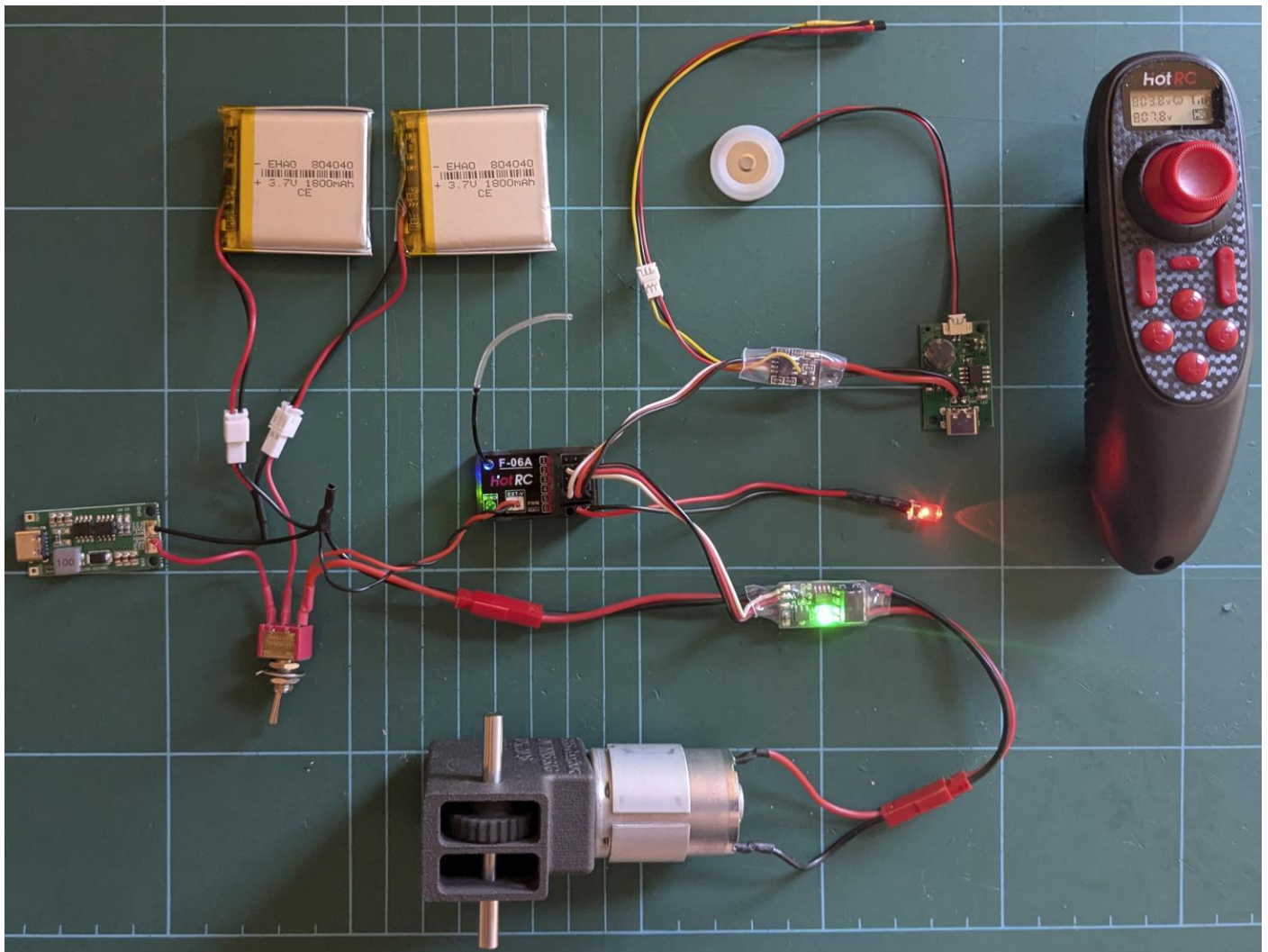
It is very important that the batteries are not physically damaged or swollen. Puncturing a cell can cause it to catch fire. The best way to check that the pouch cells are in good physical condition is to slot them into the backhead electronics carrier. The batteries should be an easy loose fit. If they are bloated and have to be forced in, then they should be replaced.



6: Bench test the electronics

The kit usually comes with pre-wired electronics ready to be plugged together as shown below.

If you have a Type C kit and are soldering the wiring yourself, then go through Appendix A before proceeding with this section.



Make sure that you carefully follow the picture to ensure everything is properly connected.

You may find it useful to zoom into the picture to get a closer look at the connections.

Note that there are two sets of 2-pin JST connectors wired to the Electronic Speed Controller (ESC) The socket goes to the switch for battery power; the plug goes to the motor.

The ESC connects to channel 2, the ultrasonics to channel 5 and the LED to channel 6

Please also view this video to see the electronics in action: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SJfrjsvGzhl>

You can test the electronics with the motor loose on the bench, or after assembling the motor into the gearbox as described in Section 8.

Once you have everything connected, make sure that the transmitter is switched off, and then switch on the receiver with the toggle switch. Just as in the picture above, you should see a continuous blue light on the receiver and a green light flashing on the receiver at approximately 1Hz. You should also see the firebox LED glow orange with occasional changes in brightness, and the green light on the Electronic Speed Controller should flash with a double beat.

Now switch on the transmitter using the small central button immediately below the joystick. The transmitter will play a short ascending tune, and the flashing green lights on both the receiver and the ESC should stop flashing and stay on continuously.

If this change in the green lights does not happen then you need to 'bind' the receiver to the transmitter so that they recognise each other.

Binding the receiver to the transmitter

Binding is performed by starting both the receiver and the transmitter in a special mode, by holding down buttons as they are switched on. The receiver has a button labelled Bind just below the antenna connection, and the transmitter has a large red button underneath labelled OK. We call this the cruise control button.

Switch off both the receiver and the transmitter. Now hold the Bind button on the receiver down and switch on with the toggle switch. The green light will flash rapidly to indicate that it is listening for a new transmitter. Now, whilst pressing the cruise control button underneath the transmitter, switch the transmitter on.

The transmitter will play its rising tune, and then beep repeatedly. Press the cruise control button again and the beeping will stop, the receiver blue light will go out, and the receiver green light will stop flashing. You have now bound the receiver and the transmitter.

You only need to do this once: the receiver will remember which transmitter it 'belongs' to. If you have more than one engine, you can bind them both to the same transmitter, but you will only be able to use one at a time.

Testing the motor and setting the zero point

Switch on the transmitter and receiver. You should now be able to run the motor forwards and backwards using the joystick. If the motor hums or turns when the stick is at its central 'off' position, use the trim buttons on the transmitter to set a zero point.

Using the cruise control

Set the motor running by pushing the joystick and then press the cruise control button and release the joystick. The motor should continue to run at the same speed, which is very helpful when running on a continuous loop.

Charging

Once you have the motor turning under the control of the transmitter you can test the charging board by connecting a USB-C charger. The charger board will show a red LED when charging the battery which turns blue when the battery is fully charged. A full charge takes 4-5 hours, which will then run the engine for several hours depending on load.

Telemetry

Check the voltage display on the transmitter to ensure that the telemetry connection is working. When fully charged it will show around 8V, reducing to about 7V when the battery is nearly flat.

Ultrasonics

Check that the ultrasonic nebuliser is working by putting a couple of drops of *distilled* water on to it and pressing the channel 5 button on the transmitter. Then bring one of the magnets up to the Hall Effect sensor. You should see some spitting and ejection of water. If not, try inverting the magnet; only one end is active.

7: Clean up and de-sprue printed parts

Prepare axles



The axles need their sharp corners removed so as not to tear the plastic parts when they are pressed on. This can be done by spinning the axle in a drill with the end against a piece of emery paper, or by careful work with a file.

Wear a glove! The axle and emery paper will get hot as you spin the axle.

Cut springs

If not supplied already formed, cut four 10mm lengths of the 2mm outside diameter spring for the axle boxes, and our 15mm lengths of the 2.5mm inside diameter spring for the buffers.

Cleaning out and sizing holes

The 3d printing process is quite low tolerance so most of the printed parts have holes which are deliberately undersized and thus need opening out. The nylon material has a tendency to smear and tear, so rather than using a proper reamer we recommend drilling out the holes with a *sharp* drill bit. It is best to do this whilst the components are still on the sprue to make them easier to handle, but it can be done with care after de-spruing.

Clean up axle boxes



Before removing the axle boxes from the sprue, clean up the holes using a sharp 5mm drill.

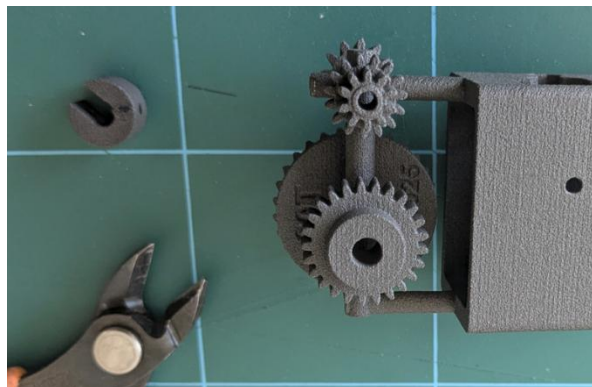
After you have drilled them out, insert one of the **5mm** diameter axles and ensure that the axle boxes are a loose running fit – there should be no binding at all: any stiffness in the axle boxes will severely impact the performance of the engine.

If you put a box on an axle and flick the box it should spin freely. If does not, work the drill bit back and forth a few times to open out the hole.

Clean up gear box components

The crown gear and the idler gear also need to spin freely on their smaller **3mm** diameter axles. Open their holes out in the same way, using a 3mm bit, and use the 'flick test' to confirm that they are free running. If they are not, work the drill bit back and forth a few times to open out the hole.

De-sprue



Now cut all items from the sprues using robust side cutters.

You will now have a lot of loose parts: don't lose them!

Carefully trim the stubs of sprue from the gears and wheels to give a smooth surface, otherwise parts may bind against the framing.

Shorten the idler gear



The idler gear as printed is a little overlength. Trim the **smaller** gear end with a craft knife until the gear slides freely between the narrow walls of the gearbox.

You do not need to remove much material, so at each step just pare off a sliver of plastic and check the fit.

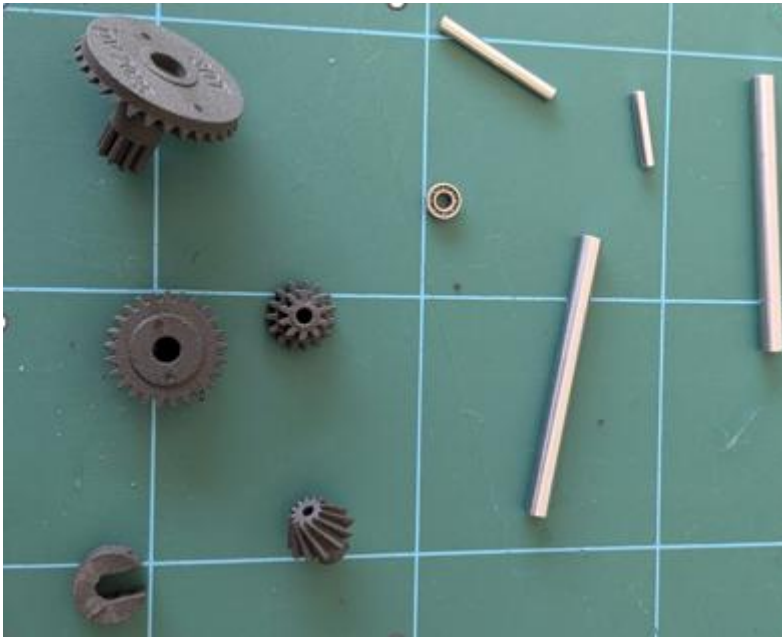
Clear the charging socket cutout

As supplied, the charger board is a little tight fitting into the firebox. Clear the inside of the opening in the firebox corner with a sharp knife so that it slides in as a tight fit.

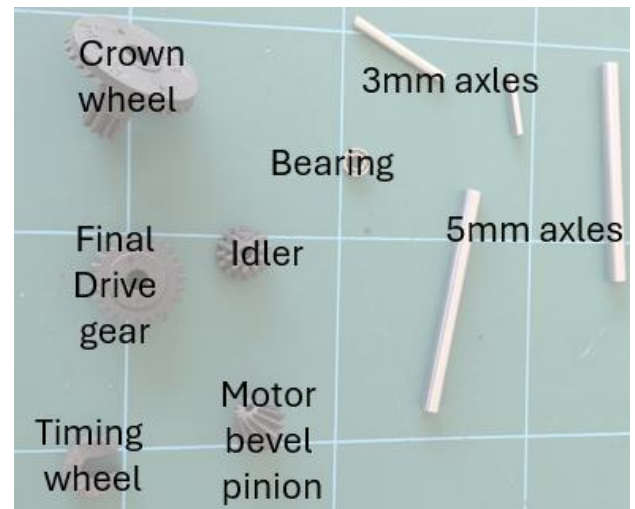
Clear the buffer stocks

The supplied buffers can be glued permanently in place, but the engine is designed to have sprung buffers. If you want to use the springing, you will need to open out the buffer stocks to allow the buffers to slide freely. Use a sharp 4mm drill bit and test for free movement, running the bit back and forth as necessary. Do not open out more than you need to as the stock needs to contain the spring. The final diameter needs to be less than the diameter of the spring, but greater than the diameter of the buffer shank.

8: Assemble the gearbox



Here are the gearbox components laid out prior to assembly.



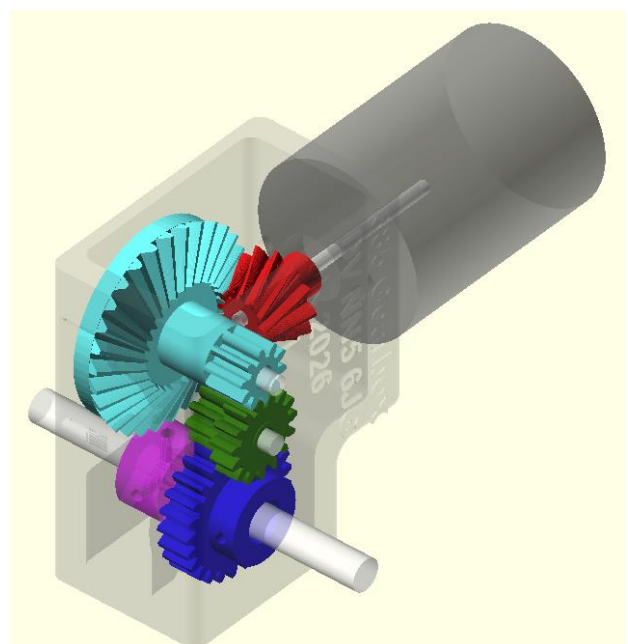
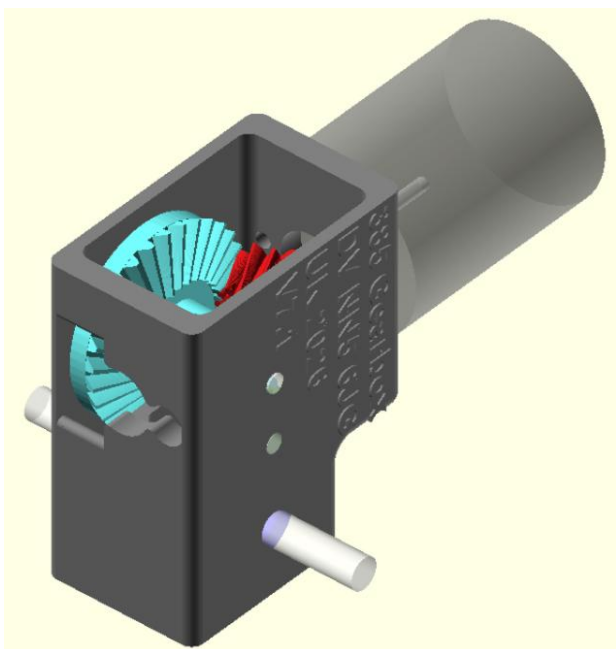
Note that the idler gear and the crown wheel rotate freely on their fixed axles but the motor bevel pinion, final drive gear, timing wheel and driven wheels are rigidly fixed to their axles which themselves rotate.

Gearbox assembly sequence

The elements of the gearbox should be assembled in this sequence:

1. Motor
2. Motor bevel pinion
3. Idler gear
4. Crown wheel
5. Final drive gear
6. Timing wheel with magnets and Hall Effect sensor

The completed box looks like this:

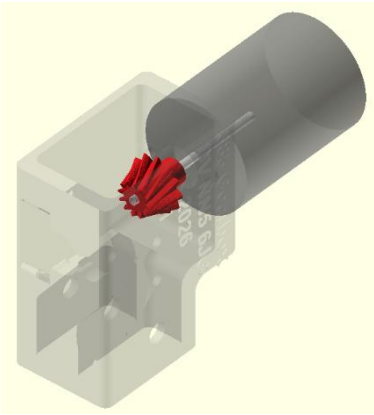


G1: Attach the motor to the gearbox frame



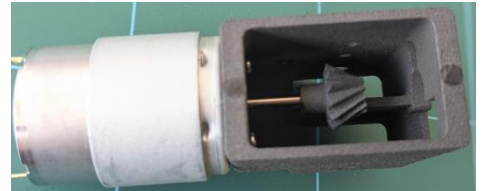
Begin by attaching the motor to the gearbox frame using the M2.6 screws. A magnetized screwdriver is a great help.

G2: Motor bevel pinion



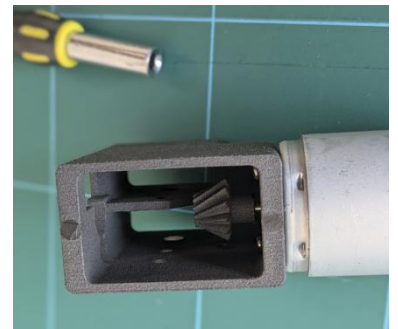
The motor bevel pinion is an interference fit, and some force may be needed to get the pinion onto shaft.

I start the process by sliding the pinion onto the shaft by down a few mm which I can do with hand pressure.



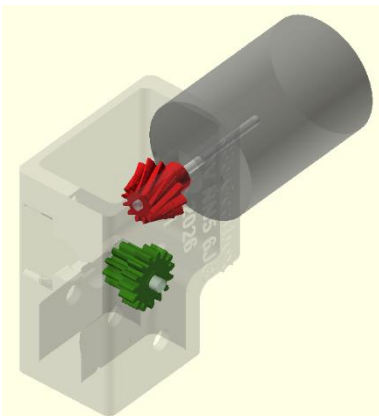
Warning: There is a danger that the motor internals might be damaged if you force the pinion on whilst holding the motor body. Instead, stand the motor up on a solid surface so that the end of the shaft is supported, and push the pinion on with force being transmitted through the shaft to the surface and not through the body of the motor.

I used a small hex-bit driver as a pusher.



It is a good idea to reconnect the motor to the electronics after fitting the pinion to make sure everything is still working correctly before proceeding.

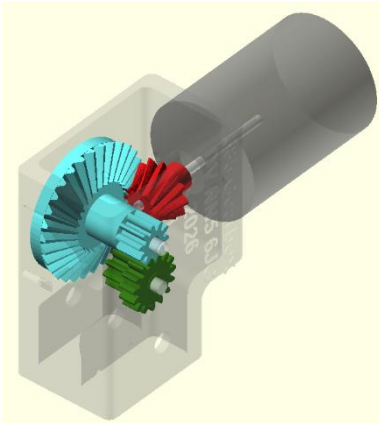
G3: Idler gear



Ensure that you have trimmed the smaller gear end with a craft knife until the gear slides freely between the narrow walls of the gearbox. Ensure that the idler spins freely (but without wobbling) on a 3mm axle. Open the bore out with a drill as necessary.

Slide the idler gear into the box, making sure that the **larger** gear is against the external wall of the gearbox and the bore is aligned with the sidewall holes, and then push the axle through. Support the inner frame with a small block of wood to prevent bowing as the shaft is inserted.

G4: Crown wheel



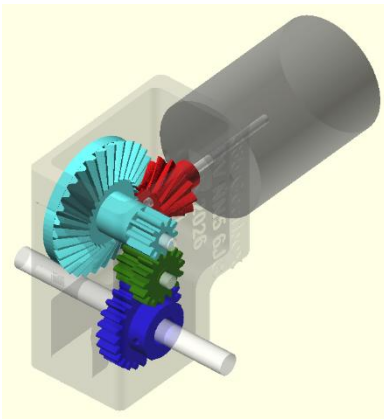
Ensure that the crown wheel rotates freely on a 3mm axle. Snap the ball race bearing into the base of the crown wheel and align the wheel with the axle holes in the gearbox housing. The crown wheel should engage with the motor pinion and the idler gear.



Insert the axle from the side of the gearbox away from the bearing. I found it helpful to put the box down on the cutting mat on its side (crown wheel down) and gently tap the axle down the last few mm to seat it in the wall of the gearbox. You might prefer to use a vice.

Check the alignment of the motor pinion by manually turning the crown wheel and then running the motor under power. Ideally the pinion should mesh tightly with the crown wheel, but not so tightly as to cause binding: there should be a small amount of backlash. Adjust the alignment by slight movements of the motor pinion up and down the motor shaft – a pair of long nosed pliers or a flat blade screwdriver will help.

G5: Final drive gear



The final drive gear is an interference fit onto the 5mm main axle. As before, I put the gearbox crown-wheel down onto the cutting mat and drove the axle through the final drive gear and gearbox wheel with gentle taps from a small hammer. You might prefer to use a vice.

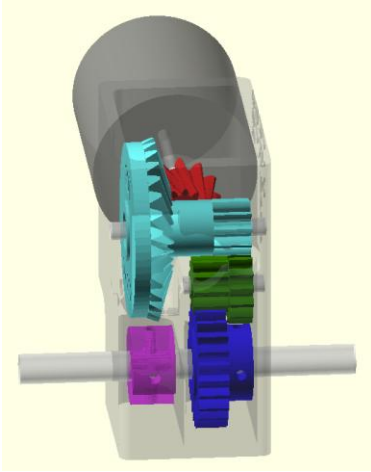
Warning: The drive gear must be a tight fit on the axle since this carries drive between the motor and the wheels.

There are holes for M2.5 grub screws if your gear is loose; drill out the holes to 2mm and carefully drive the screw in – it will self-tap.



Alternatively, put a drop of super glue down the hole and rotate the axle through the gear to spread the superglue round the inside of the glue. **Only do this after the wheels have been fitted** since once glued you will not be able to adjust the position of the gear on the axle.

G6: Timing wheel



The timing wheel has four holes each of which is a push fit for the magnets (item 34 in the Section 2 parts list). In practice, only two magnets should be fitted, otherwise the gap between them is so small that the ultrasonic smoke generator will be on all the time. Even with only two, the puffing effect is best observed at low speed.

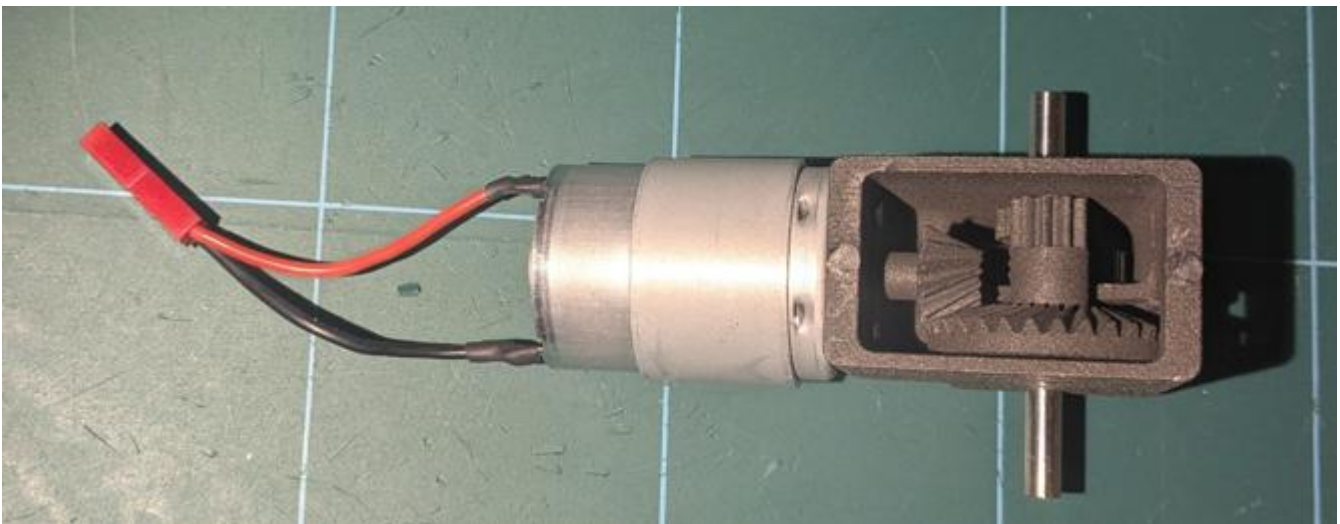
The polarity of the magnets matters. During the electronics bench test you will have identified the 'hot' end – make sure you fit the magnets correctly.

The wheel then just clips onto the 5mm axle in the cavity in front of the crown wheel.

Running in

Run the gearbox on the bench for a while to get everything bedded in, then check alignments.

Warning: The 3mm crown wheel axle and the 3mm idler axle should be gripped by the walls of the gearbox and should not turn. If the axles do rotate, then they will eventually work their way out. The gears would then come out of alignment and probably be damaged. After running in, if you see that they are moving, then let a couple of drops of superglue seep into the axle/wall interface and leave to set.

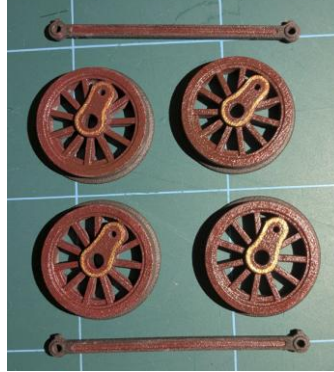


Warning: Do not be tempted to add any sort of lubricants as the nylon gears do not need them – all you will do is create a sticky dust-collecting mess.

9: Apply livery

It is best to paint and line the wheels, coupling rods, backhead and body before proceeding further. In particular, it is much easier to paint the wheels when they are flat on the bench.

These examples are from Elizabeth Scott's Cadbury No. 14 engine, but as an industrial engine, a wide choice of liveries are acceptable. A GNR livery would echo the inspiration for Greenly's design. The gallery images after Section 12 might provide some inspiration.



The white resin components and the firebox have been sprayed with car-body grey primer and then painted with acrylic paints. The chassis and the inside of the wheels (and rims) have been left in their native black nylon

The lettering and numbering has been done with computer-printed water-slide transfers that are then over-painted by hand to soften their edges and look good at a distance.

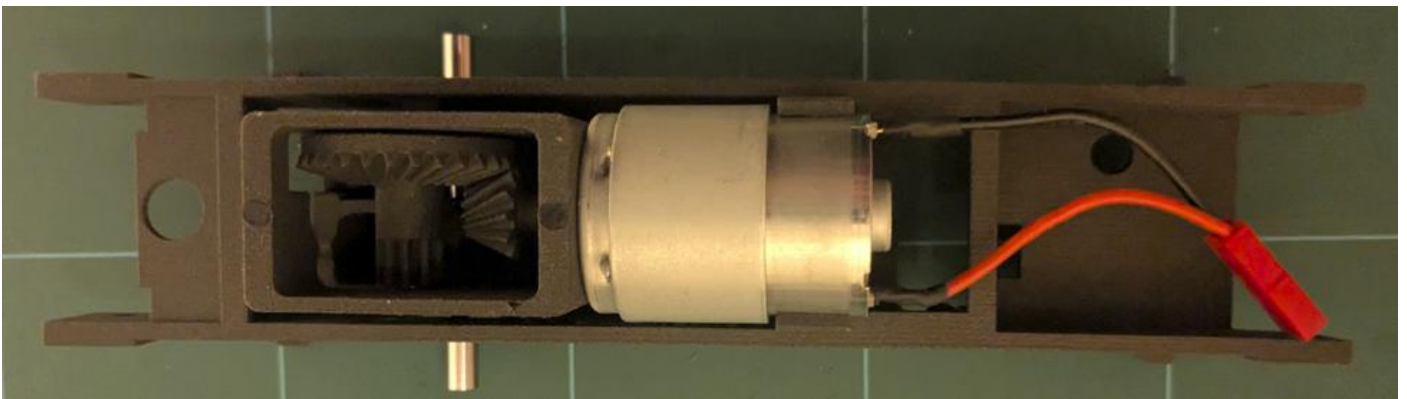
10: Press wheels and assemble the chassis

The chassis is a one piece nylon print which includes the motor bracket.



The chassis clips together in an ingenious way: the motor goes into the round bracket on top, and the sprung axle boxes clip into the frames. Everything can be unclipped, so you can safely try a dry run before final assembly.

Warning: It is important to ensure that the motor is facing the correct way!



Adding axle boxes and pressing wheels onto the main axle



Add an axle box to one side of the main axle. The flange on the axle box should be on the outside as in this picture – it provides a rubbing surface for the wheel.

Now press on a wheel. This requires considerable force, and the wheel needs to be set accurately at a right angle to the axle – it is easy to press the wheel on at a slight angle so you end up with a wobbly wheel. (Guess how I know.) The best way to do this is with a vice: do not attempt to do it by hand. Check the alignments carefully with a set-square, and drive the axle in slowly by tightening the vice jaws, checking as you go.

Now repeat for the other side of the main axle, and then make up the undriven axle in the same way.

Fitting the motor and gearbox assembly

Easing the motor through the frames requires some care as there are several lumps and bumps on the inside of the frame that can block the motor's passage. Insert the top of the motor from below, and slide it around to find the widest part of the frames, then ease the frames apart slightly to allow the motor waistband through.

Fitting springs and axle boxes



Invert the frame and drop springs into the spring pockets for the axles. Rest the driven axle and its axle boxes on the top edge of the frame and then rotate both axle boxes until the indent for the top of the spring is facing down. Now push the assembly down – it should mate with the frame with a satisfying click, with the springs providing suspension.

If all did not go well, unclip the axle boxes from the frame and try again.

Repeat this with the undriven axle, and then seat the motor properly in its clip.

Place the chassis right side up and check that all four springs are effective and nothing is rubbing by bouncing the chassis on the wheels.

Fitting coupling rods

The coupling rods rotate on crank pins which are screwed into the wheel. Ideally, you will have already given the holes a 'start' as described in Section 7 but if you missed that step all is not lost: you just need to be careful.

If you already have the wheels on the axles, then it is still worth screwing the crank pins in for a turn or two without the coupling rods in position. Check they are going in at right angles to the wheel viewed from all sides.

Now undo the crank pins, put one connecting rod on and then screw in the crank pins so that the rods are free to move but close to the wheel.

Traditionally (but not universally) the rods should be 90 degree out of phase with the left hand rod (looking ahead) leading. It does not in fact affect operation if the angle is, say, 85 or 95 degrees. The critical thing is that both rods should be precisely horizontal at every position of the wheels. So-called 'crossed rods' occur when the two rods are not precisely parallel with each other, and this will cause the engine to run unevenly or completely seize up.

I recommend that you put one rod on one side and use this as a datum, measuring the height of the crank pin above the rail carefully to make sure both pins are the same height. Then on the other side of the engine ensure the driven wheel is where you want it (approx 90 degrees before or after the first side). Then twist the undriven wheel so that it too has a crankpin hole exactly the same height above the rail and fit the coupling rods.

Rotate the driven wheels by hand to feel that nothing is binding: tweak the undriven wheel if necessary. Then put power onto the motor and ensure that everything runs sweetly.

11: Fit the electronics

Coming soon

Fit the Hall Effect sensor into the gearbox

The sensor can be inserted in the bottom flange of the gearbox shell. The trapezoidal cutout will need little easing with a sharp knife and provided this is not overdone the insulation will hold the sensor in place. Insert the sensor chamfered face down, facing the rotating magnets and as close as practicable without them hitting.



12: Assemble bodywork, buffers and ballast

The white resin body will take rattle-can paint directly, but a first coat of car body primer coat is advisable. Some livery suggestions are shown in the next section.

The engine is mostly plastic, and thus very light. There is plenty of power to pull heavy loads, but the engine needs mass to achieve the necessary adhesion and avoid wheel spin. Adding about 180g of ballast is recommended, most easily achieved by adding self-adhesive tyre balancing weights. Alternatively, a piece of lead flashing may be folded into the tank interior.

Handrail knobs may be superglued into the holes in the body (which may need opening out). They are designed to take 2mm wires which may look a little chunky. Some builders have used 1mm or 1.2mm rodding which is closer to a scale size with a little dab of glue to keep them in place.

Nylon buffers and coupling hooks are supplied. The buffers can be glued permanently in place, or you can add the supplied springs with the buffer nuts tightened directly onto the buffer shanks. If using sprung buffers, ensure that you have opened out the buffer shanks with a 4mm drill to allow the buffers to move freely.

Gallery



David Viewing's rattle-can painted and vinyl wrapped prototypes in action at the 2025 G1MRA AGM



Steve Andrews' weathered NCB loco with added external cylinders, safety valves, bunker and spectacle bars



William Ayerst's completed engine and Roger Hopkin's Archie



Elizabeth Scott's Cadbury engine running on Mike and Christine Blands' track with Northern Finescale vans



David Viewing's Gauge 3 prototype running on the Warton Road layout at the 2026 National Garden Rail Show



The surviving GNR J13 preserved in the National Collection

Picture credit: Science Museum Group Collection © The Board of Trustees of the Science Museum under terms of license [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 Licence](#) for non-commercial use

Appendix A: Soldering the Type C kit electronics

We assume that you have the necessary skills to solder electronic components; if not then please either acquire them by following Appendix B, or purchase either the Type B pluggable version of the kit or the Type C Ready-To-Run engine.

Collect tools

1. Small side cutters



2. Small needle nose pliers



3. I find a pair of spring loaded tweezers useful for handling small components



4. A wire stripper is very helpful when removing insulation from thin wires



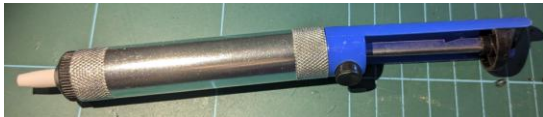
5. A soldering iron or soldering station, and some resin-cored solder



This yellow style of iron is common, but I recommend using a temperature controlled soldering station like the one on the right.



6. Mistakes happen, so a solder sucker for undoing joints is helpful



7. For connecting to open terminals on the switch, motor and LED, 2mm inside diameter heat shrink sleeving provides insulation and mechanical support.



8. After soldering, a hair dryer or heat gun is needed to shrink the sleeving.



9. For close up work, an Optivisor really helps. This is a real one with glass lenses; there are cheaper versions available with not-very-well moulded plastic lenses which are false economy in my view.



Component check

Warning: charging boards come in different sizes. The firebox is designed for the **37mm** variant. Shorter boards will not locate securely – if you have one of those please request a replacement.



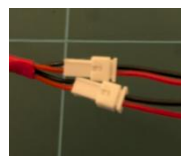
RIGHT - 37mm



WRONG – too short

General advice

We recommend using heat shrink tubing for connections to the switch, the motor and the LED so as to provide some mechanical support for the wires and insulation against the elements – Gauge 1 tracks are rather hostile environments. You will also need wide heat shrink sleeving to re-encapsulate the RC switch after soldering.

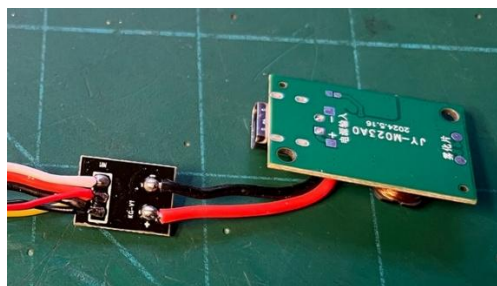


Warning: connectors are keyed, but can have the red and black leads connected either way round, which is unhelpful. To avoid nasty surprises, always connect red to red and black to black; if the connector leads do not match up, then ease the pins out of the shell and rearrange like this.

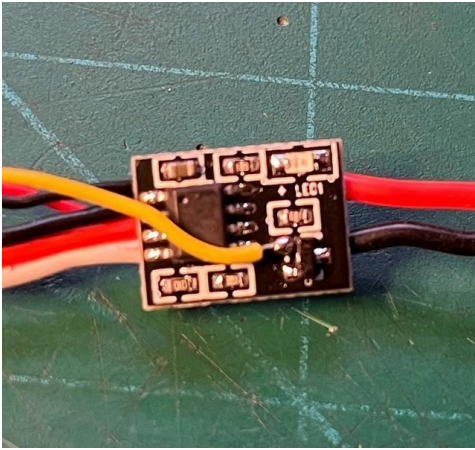
Modifying the electronic switch

The sensor generates 'puffs' by shutting off the output of the RC switch as the magnet wheel rotates. It does this by shutting off the output transistor in a 'cluge' which has been shown to work reliably.

First, carefully peels back the Heatshrink covering from the switch pcb taking care not to damage any of the components. Prepare the JST-PH 1.25mm connector so the yellow wire is approx 30cm long, making the red and black wires slightly shorter. Bare the insulation for 1-2mm and pre-tin the ends. Attach the black and red wires by soldering them on top of the existing wires on the board.



Now, pre-tin the transistor pin as indicated and attach the yellow wire taking care not to short to anything else.



Re insulate the board with transparent heatshrink 22mm wide (not supplied).

Magnetic sensor (A3144) detects the passage of magnets rotating past on a special 'magnet wheel' installed in the bottom of the gearbox. Positions for 4 magnets at 90 degrees are provided for the 2 -cylinder engine but in practice at model railway speeds the smoke generator quickly gets 'swamped' by the rate of 'chuffs'. A better compromise is to install just two magnets in opposing positions, which gives a detectable 'chuff' up to a reasonable forward speed.

Magnet Polarity

The magnet polarity is important because the sensor works in one way only. The chamfered side of the sensor should face the magnet's South Pole. You can find this by trial and error, unless you happen to have a compass! Both magnets must have the same polarity facing outward.

Once you have established the correct polarity, push the magnets into two opposing holes in the magnet wheel until about 1mm projects. I find the best way to do this is to pick up the magnet with a wide flat screwdriver blade or similar. The magnet wheel clips onto the driven axle and can be removed at any time for alteration if required.

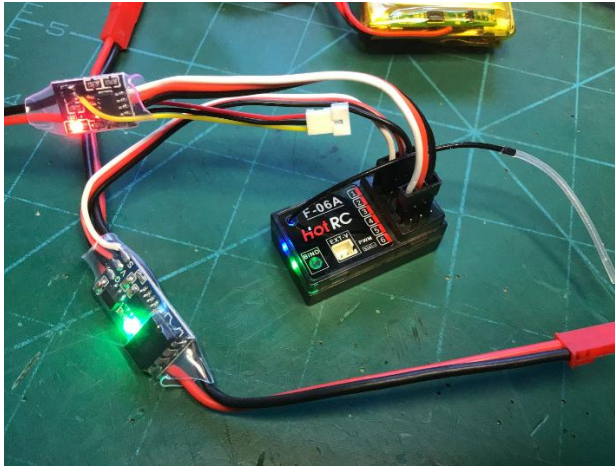
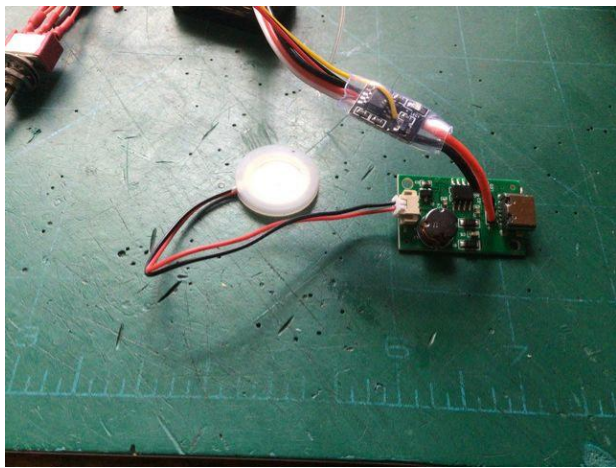
Sensor Installation

Once the three wires from the female JST connector (The one with receptacles for the pins) have been attached and insulated,

Connecting the Ultrasonic oscillator

To save space, we connect the RC switch directly to the smoke unit oscillator. This means cutting off the JST connector leaving about 20cm of wire projecting. The connector can be re-used as part of the on/off switch assembly.

Pre-tin the ends of the remaining wire stubs after removing about 2mm of insulation. Also pre-tin the two pads on the oscillator board, immediately behind the connector, noting they are marked + and -.. Solder the RC switch output leads to these pads, observing red goes to +, etc.



Appendix B: Learning to solder

These notes are designed to help you develop skill in soft soldering electronic components.

What soldering is, and what it is not

Soldering is used to join together metal components with a 'solder' which is itself a metal, but one which melts at a temperature well below the melting point of those components.

Solder is not glue. It is important that the molten solder 'gets into' the metal of the components forming a hybrid metallic zone and does not just sit on the surface.

Soldering is not welding. When welding, the interface between the components is heated to melting point so that the parts fuse directly together. Often a filler stick is also melted to increase the volume of material at the joint, but the filler stick is made of similar material to the joined components, and is not a solder.

The problem of oxidation

Most metals form an oxide layer when heated in air. These oxides do not behave like metals, and they stop the solder from merging properly with the components.

We could get round this by (a) soldering in a vacuum (impractical at home), (b) soldering under a gas blanket which excludes the oxygen (not very practical at home, but used in some welding operations), or (c) introducing a substance called a *flux* which inhibits oxide formation by grabbing all the oxygen molecules near the joint so that the surface of the components stay as clean metal.

Three soldering styles

There are three styles of soldering commonly encountered in the home workshop,

1. Soft soldering of electronics using resin-cored tin-copper solder wire which melts at around 230 Celsius and has its own flux 'built-in'. This style only needs a low-power electric soldering iron.
2. Soft soldering of metal pieces using tin-copper solder and a separate flux which typically needs a hot flame to heat the rather large components, or a resistance soldering unit
3. Hard or *silver* soldering of metal pieces using silver-based solder that melts at around 650 Celsius and a separate flux, and which requires components to be heated by a flame until they are glowing red hot.

These notes only cover case 1: soldering of electronic components using a low-power electrical soldering iron and electronic-style solder with a flux core.

How to get started

You need to get a feel for how solder melts, and how to work at speed to avoid melting the insulation on wire or (worse) 'cooking' the electronic components.



Start by getting a soldering station. Many of us grew up with the ubiquitous yellow soldering iron and its spring-style rest which almost seemed designed to be unstable.

Of course, these can be used, but really they now belong in museums because temperature-controlled soldering stations complete with a selection of bits and a reel of solder like the one shown here are available for not much more than £30.

The blue rectangle is a sponge which is kept wet in use so that excess solder and oxides on the tip of the iron can be wiped off.